mother, Hiraben. The first television image post-victory was well-thought-out—Modi sitting on a chair being blessed by his mother and surrounded by a few other smiling relatives. Narendra, who had left home as a teenager to become an RSS pracharak, had now returned, if only for a photo op, as the prime minister designate. It had been a truly remarkable journey.

His first public comments after the victory were made at a thanksgiving speech in Vadodara, one of the two seats he had contested from. The margin was a near-record 5.7 lakh votes. In victory, he appeared statesman-like. Immaculately dressed, as always, in a trademark beige and white half kurta, he said, 'I want to tell all my fellow Indians that in letter and spirit I will take all Indians with me.' These were not the words of chief minister Modi—this was prime minister Modi talking.

Modi promised he was here to stay. 'I want to make the twenty-first century India's century; it will take ten years, not very long.' As the ever-faithful crowd in their Modi caps cheered him on and screamed, 'Modi, Modi', the showman was in full form. 'Achhe Din,' he said loudly. The near-hysterical crowd bellowed back, 'Aa Gaye!'

A little after 8.30 p.m., he had his last public function of the day, and as it turned out, as chief minister too—a speech to another crowd of admirers in Ahmedabad. In 1971, Modi had come to the city to work in the anonymity of his uncle's small canteen before moving up the political ladder. Now, he was back. This was another homecoming to remember. His tired voice was beginning to crack but he was determined to have a final word. '*Desh chal pada hai, hamein kadam milana hai'* (The country has begun to march ahead, we have to match its steps).

The mood at the Congress headquarters was in sharp contrast. The party had put up small tents with coolers for journalists to protect them from the heat, with special arrangements for food and refreshments. They need not have bothered. By early afternoon, the locale wore a deserted look. Winners love to come on television, losers are good at the disappearing act.

A little after 4 p.m., Sonia and Rahul Gandhi made an appearance before the television cameras outside the party office. Both of them congratulated the new government and accepted responsibility for the defeat. 'The